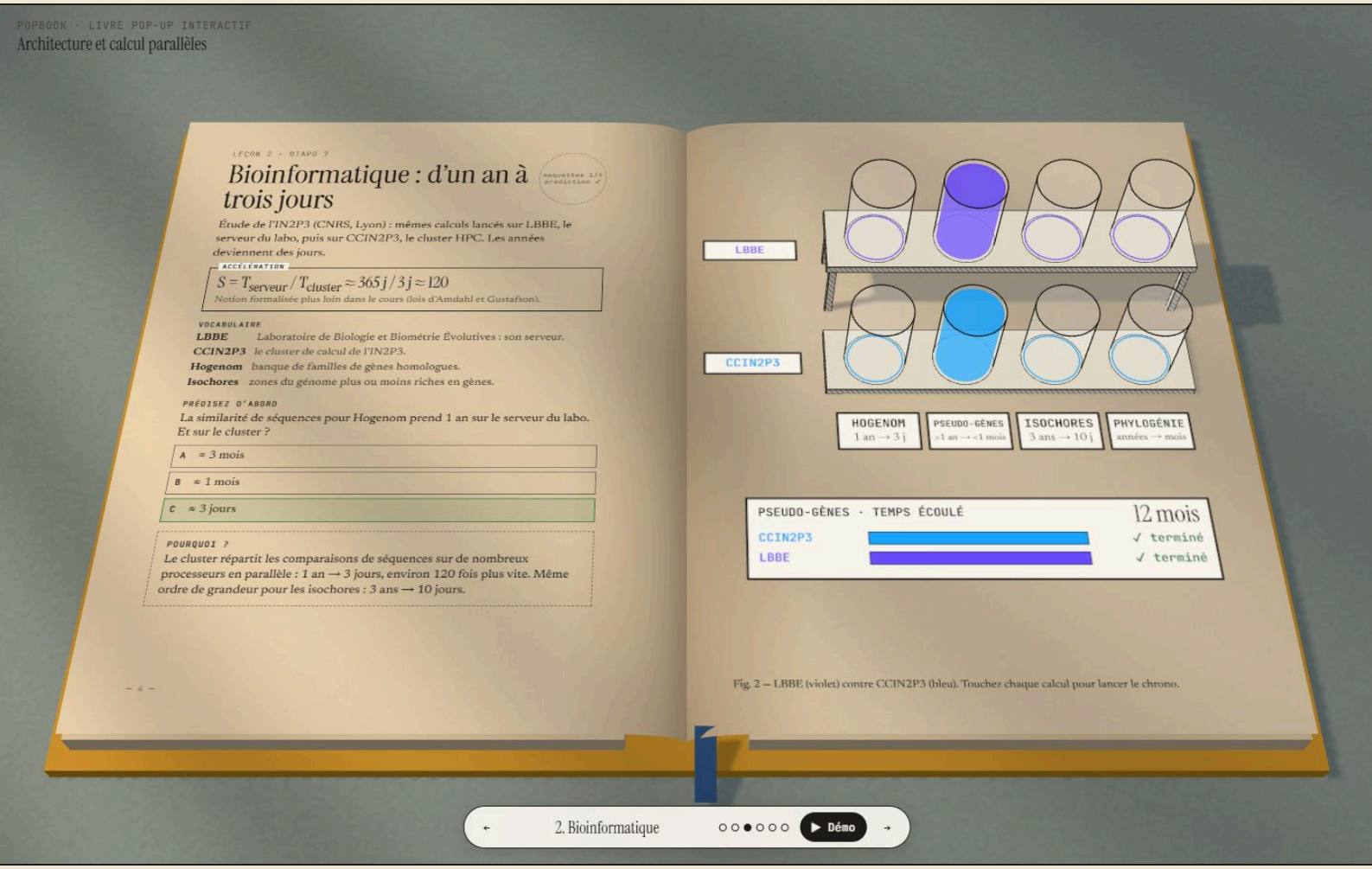
BEGINNER'S GUIDE · NO CODING NEEDED

PopBook Studio

Turn your course PDF into an interactive 3D pop-up book you can click, play with and share. This guide takes you from zero to your first book, one small step at a time.



~20 minutes

to install everything the first time. After that, opening PopBook takes 30 seconds.

Free & open source

PopBook itself costs nothing. You only pay for the AI you connect, if it isn't free.

Windows or Mac

Any recent computer with Chrome, Edge, Firefox or Safari.

BEFORE YOU START

What you're going to do

PopBook runs on **your own computer**. You install two small things, download PopBook, start it, and then everything happens in your web browser.

1	Install Node.js — the engine PopBook runs on	5 min · once
2	Download PopBook from GitHub	2 min · once
3	Start PopBook and open it in your browser	3 min · once
4	Connect an AI (Claude Code or an API key)	5–10 min · once
5	Drop your PDF and build your book	2–5 min · every book
6	Read, play with and share your book	as long as you like

At the end: a one-page "next time" card, a troubleshooting table and tips for better books.

What you need

- ✓ A Windows 10/11 or macOS computer, with an internet connection.
- ✓ A course PDF (slides or a textbook chapter). Start with **5–10 pages**.
- ✓ One way to use an AI: a **Claude subscription** (Pro or Max) *or* an **API key** from Anthropic, Google or OpenAI. Step 4 explains both.

Words you'll see in this guide

Terminal
A window where you type commands instead of clicking. On Windows it's called *Command Prompt*, *PowerShell* or *Terminal*; on Mac it's *Terminal*. You'll only type a few short lines — this guide gives you each one to copy.

Node.js
Free software that lets PopBook run on your computer. You install it once and forget about it.

npm
A helper that comes with Node.js. PopBook uses it to download its parts (`npm install`) and to start (`npm start`).

localhost
"This computer". When PopBook is running, you open it at the address `http://localhost:5173` in your browser. Nothing is put on the internet.

API key
A secret password-like code that lets PopBook use an AI service (Claude, Gemini, ChatGPT) with your account. Keep it private.

Claude Code
Anthropic's AI assistant that runs on your computer. If you have a Claude subscription, PopBook can use it directly, with no API key.

1 INSTALL NODE.JS · ONCE

Install Node.js

Node.js is the engine PopBook runs on. It's free and installs like any other program.

1. Go to **nodejs.org** and click the big download button for the **LTS** version ("Long Term Support" — the stable one). Any LTS version from 18 upward works; take the newest LTS.
2. Open the file you downloaded and click **Next** through the installer, keeping all the default choices.
3. When it's finished, **close any terminal windows** you already had open (new ones will know about Node.js, old ones won't).

Open a terminal

Windows

Press the **Windows key**, type **cmd**, and press **Enter**. A black *Command Prompt* window opens.

Mac

Press **⌘ + Space**, type **Terminal**, and press **Enter**.

HOW TO TYPE A COMMAND

Every black box in this guide is something to type in the terminal. Type it exactly (or copy-paste it), then press **Enter**. Don't type the `>` sign at the start: it just means "type here".

Check that it worked

In the terminal, type this and press Enter:

```
> node -v
v24.21.0  ← you should see a version number like this
```

If you see a version number starting with **v18** or higher, you're done with this step. 🎉

IF IT SAYS "'NODE' IS NOT RECOGNIZED" OR "COMMAND NOT FOUND"

Close the terminal, open a new one and try again. If it still fails, restart your computer — the installer sometimes needs that before the `node` command works.

2 DOWNLOAD POPBOOK · ONCE

Download PopBook

PopBook lives on GitHub, a website where people share code. You don't need a GitHub account to download it.

Easiest way: download a ZIP

1. Open **github.com/AlphaaCode/Popbook** in your browser.
2. Click the green **<> Code** button, then **Download ZIP**.
3. Find the downloaded file (usually in your **Downloads** folder), right-click it and choose **Extract All...** (Windows) or just double-click it (Mac).
4. Move the extracted folder somewhere easy to find, for example your **Documents** folder. It's called **Popbook-main**. You can rename it to **Popbook** if you like.

> **IMPORTANT**
> Don't run PopBook from inside the ZIP file. Always use the **extracted** folder — the one you can open and see files like `README.md` and `package.json` in.

Alternative: with Git (if you already use it)

If you have Git installed, this downloads PopBook into a folder called **Popbook** and makes it easy to get updates later with `git pull`:

```
> git clone https://github.com/AlphaaCode/Popbook.git
```

What's inside the folder

FOLDER / FILE	WHAT IT IS
`books`	Your finished books are saved here. Two example books come with it.
`app`, `viewer`, `lib`	PopBook's own parts. You don't need to touch them.
`.env.example`	A settings file you can copy if you want to save API keys (optional, see step 4).
`README.md`	The technical documentation, for developers.

3 START POPBOOK

Start PopBook

Now open a terminal **inside the PopBook folder**, download its parts once, and start it.

Open a terminal in the PopBook folder

Windows

Open the **Popbook** folder in File Explorer. Click once in the **address bar** at the top (where the folder path is), type **cmd** and press **Enter**. A terminal opens, already in the right folder.

Mac

In Terminal, type **cd** followed by a space, then **drag the Popbook folder** from Finder into the Terminal window and press **Enter**.

Download PopBook's parts (first time only)

```
> npm install
added 4 packages … found 0 vulnerabilities
```

This takes 10–60 seconds. Ignore any yellow "warn" lines — only red "ERR" lines are a problem.

Start PopBook

```
> npm start

  📖  PopBook Studio is running →  http://127.0.0.1:5173
```

1. Open your browser (Chrome or Edge works best) and go to **localhost:5173**.
2. **Leave the terminal window open** the whole time you use PopBook. It's the "engine room". If you close it, PopBook stops.
3. When you're finished for the day, click the terminal and press **Ctrl + C** to stop PopBook (or just close the window).

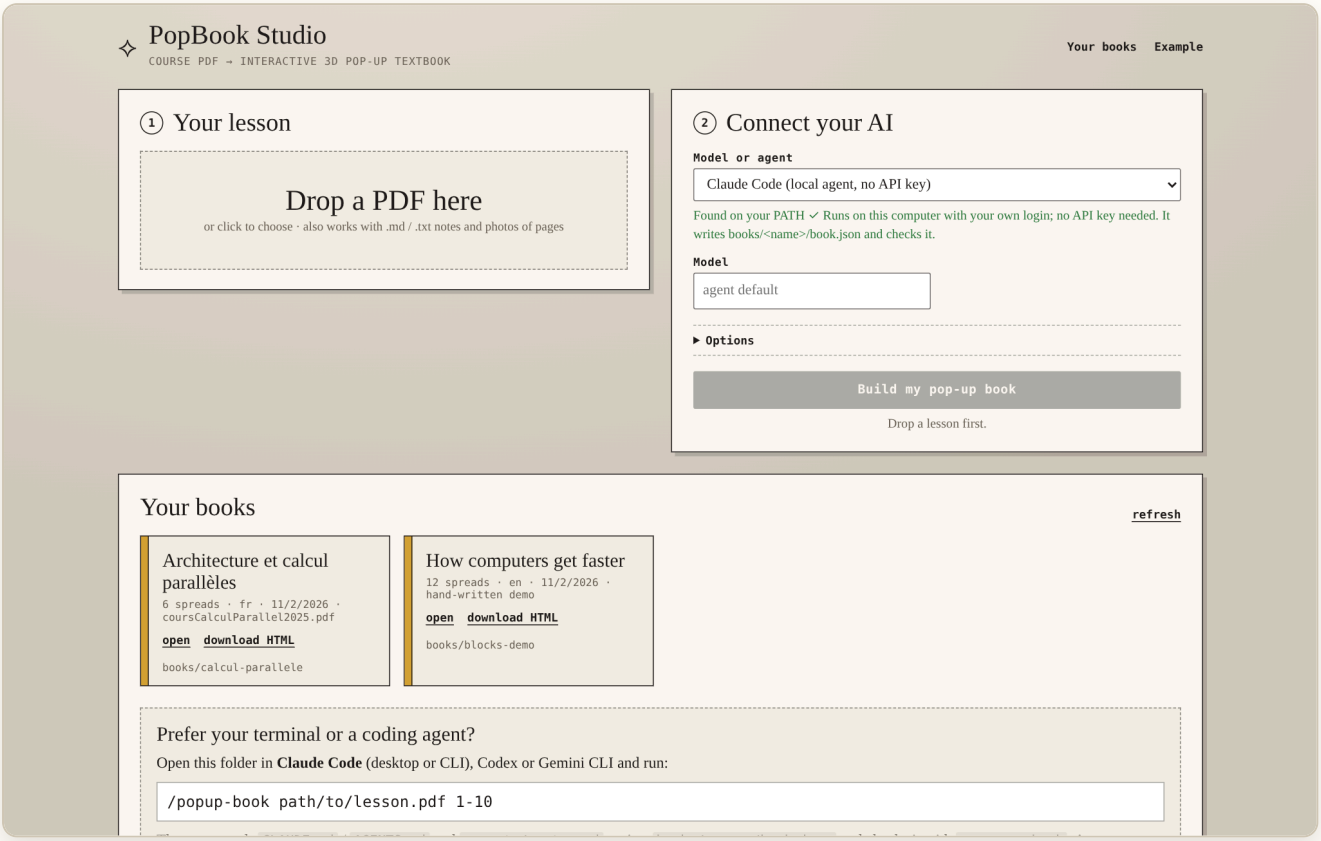
WINDOWS: "RUNNING SCRIPTS IS DISABLED ON THIS SYSTEM"

You're in PowerShell, which blocks `npm` by default. Easiest fix: use **Command Prompt** instead (type **cmd** in the folder's address bar, as above). Or run this once in PowerShell, then try again: `Set-ExecutionPolicy -Scope CurrentUser RemoteSigned`

A QUICK TOUR

This is PopBook Studio

Everything happens on this one page. You'll fill it in from left to right.



PopBook Studio at localhost:5173.

AREA	WHAT IT DOES
① **Your lesson**	Where you drop your PDF and choose which pages to turn into a book.
② **Connect your AI**	Where you choose which AI writes the book, and paste a key if it needs one.
Build my pop-up book	Starts the work. It turns black (clickable) once ① and ② are ready.
Your books	Every book you've made, with **open** and **download HTML** links.

TRY THE EXAMPLE FIRST

Before connecting any AI, click **Example** at the top right of PopBook, or open an example from **Your books**. You'll see what a finished book looks like and check that 3D works on your computer.

4 CONNECT AN AI · ONCE

Choose your AI

PopBook doesn't include an AI — it uses one you already have access to. The AI reads your pages and writes the book. Pick **one** of these:

OPTION	WHAT YOU NEED	GOOD FOR
Claude Code recommended	A Claude Pro or Max subscription	No API key, no extra bill: it uses your subscription. Best quality. Our 5-page test took about 2 minutes.
Claude API	An Anthropic API key (pay per use)	Best quality if you don't have a subscription. Reads your PDF's pictures and tables directly.
Google Gemini API	A Gemini API key from Google AI Studio	Also reads the PDF directly. The default model needs a **paid** (billing-enabled) Google project; the free tier won't work with it.
OpenAI API	An OpenAI API key (pay per use)	If you already pay for OpenAI's API.
OpenAI-compatible advanced	A local AI app like Ollama or LM Studio	Free and fully offline, but needs a strong computer and gives weaker books.

WHICH ONE SHOULD I PICK?

If you pay for Claude (Pro or Max): use **Claude Code** (next page).
If you don't: get an API key from Anthropic or Google (page after next).

YOUR KEY STAYS WITH YOU

PopBook runs only on your computer and only talks to the AI you choose. A key you paste is used for that build and isn't saved to a file, unless you tick **remember on this computer** (it's then kept in this browser only).

4A OPTION A · CLAUDE CODE

Use Claude Code (no API key)

Claude Code is a free program from Anthropic that uses your Claude subscription. You install it once and log in once. (If a command below fails, search "install Claude Code" for Anthropic's current one.)

1 · Install Claude Code

Windows Open **PowerShell** (Windows key → type **powershell** → Enter) and paste:

```
irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
```

Mac In Terminal, paste:

```
curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
```

2 · Log in once

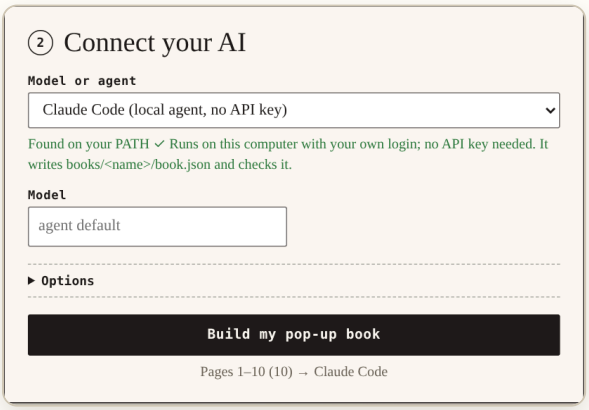
Close the terminal and open a new one, then type:

```
> claude
```

Follow what it says: it opens your browser so you can log in with your Claude account. When you see Claude's prompt, type **/exit** and press Enter.

3 · Restart PopBook and pick it

PopBook only notices Claude Code when it starts. Go to PopBook's terminal, press **Ctrl + C**, then `npm start` again and refresh the browser page. In **Connect your AI**, choose **Claude Code (local agent, no API key)**. You should see a green **Found on your PATH ✓**:



Claude Code is found and ready. Leave **Model** empty to use its default, then continue with step 5.

IT SAYS "NOT INSTALLED"?

PopBook can't see the `claude` command yet. Close **every** terminal, open a new one in the PopBook folder, run `npm start` again and refresh the page. If it still says "not installed", restart your computer.

4B OPTION B · AN API KEY

Use an API key

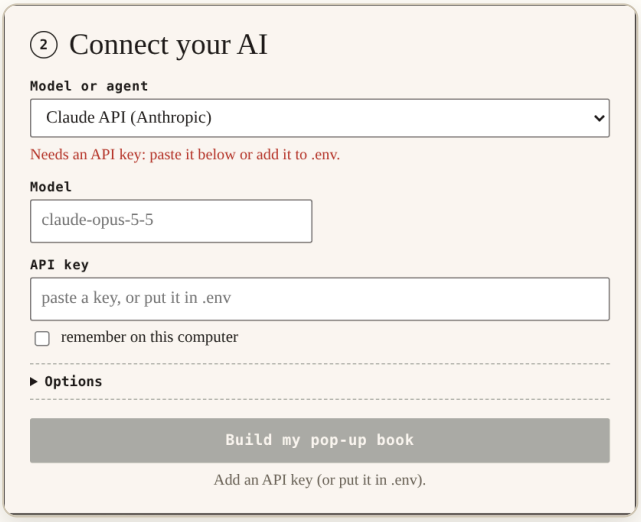
An API key lets PopBook use an AI service with your account. You create it on the service's website and paste it into PopBook.

SERVICE	WHERE TO GET A KEY
Claude API	Go to **console.anthropic.com** → sign up → add some credit under *Billing* → **API Keys** → **Create Key**.
Gemini API	Go to **aistudio.google.com** → sign in with Google → **Get API key** → **Create API key**. Turn on billing for the project: the default Gemini model isn't on the free tier.
OpenAI API	Go to **platform.openai.com** → sign up → add credit → **API keys** → **Create new secret key**.

Copy the key right away: most sites only show it once. It's a long code, often starting with something like `sk-…`.

Paste it into PopBook

1. In **Connect your AI**, choose the service (for example **Claude API (Anthropic)**).
2. Paste your key in **API key**. Tick **remember on this computer** if you don't want to paste it every time.
3. Leave **Model** as it is, unless you know you want a different one.



The red hint disappears once a key is pasted.

SAVE MONEY ON CLAUDE

The default Claude model is the most capable and also the most expensive. For cheaper books, type **claude-sonnet-5-5** in **Model**.

KEEP YOUR KEY SECRET

Never post it in a video, a screenshot or a chat. If you ever show it by accident, delete it on the website and create a new one.

5 EVERY BOOK

Make your book

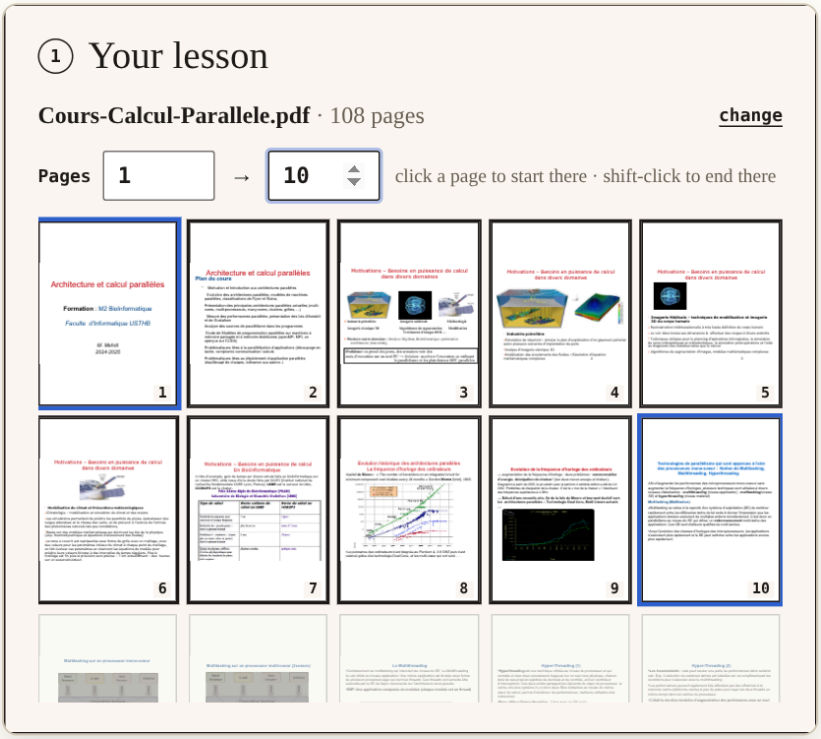
Drop the PDF, choose the pages, and click build.

1 · Drop your lesson

Drag your PDF onto **Drop a PDF here** (or click it to choose a file). PopBook also accepts `.txt` / `.md` notes and photos of pages.

2 · Choose the pages

Type the first and last page in **Pages**, or **click a page** to start there and **Shift + click** another page to end there. The chosen pages get a blue frame.



Pages 1 to 10 of a 108-page course are selected.

> **HOW MANY PAGES?**
> Start with **5–10 pages**. Smaller books are faster, cheaper and easier to check. The AI makes about one spread (two-page lesson) for every 1–3 slides.

3 · Options (optional)

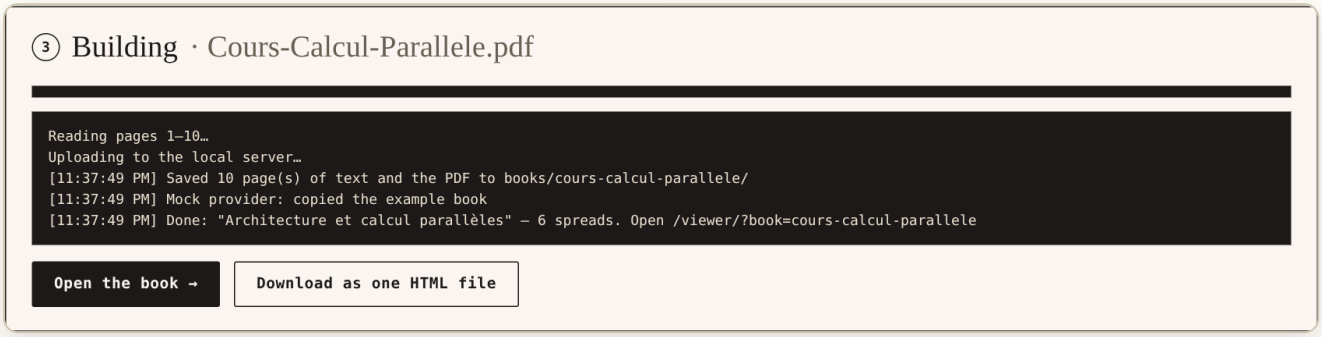
Click **Options** under the AI settings to change:

- **Book language** — keep "Same as the source", or make a French course into an English book, for example. Arabic is supported.
- **Book folder name** — the book's name inside the `books` folder.
- **Extra instructions** — talk to the AI in plain words: "Students are first-year biology", "Make the quizzes harder".

5 EVERY BOOK (CONTINUED)

4 · Build

Click **Build my pop-up book**. A **Building** panel shows what the AI is doing, line by line. It usually takes **1–5 minutes** for 10 pages. You can keep the page open and wait — no need to do anything.



When the last line says **Done**, two buttons appear.

BUTTON	WHAT IT DOES
Open the book →	Opens your new book in a new tab.
Download as one HTML file	Saves the whole book as a single file you can send to anyone (see step 6).

IT SAYS ERROR?

Read the red line — it usually says what's wrong in plain words: a wrong key, no credit left, or an unknown model name. Fix it and click **Build** again. If the AI's answer was "cut off", open **Options** and lower **Pages per AI call** to 5–8.

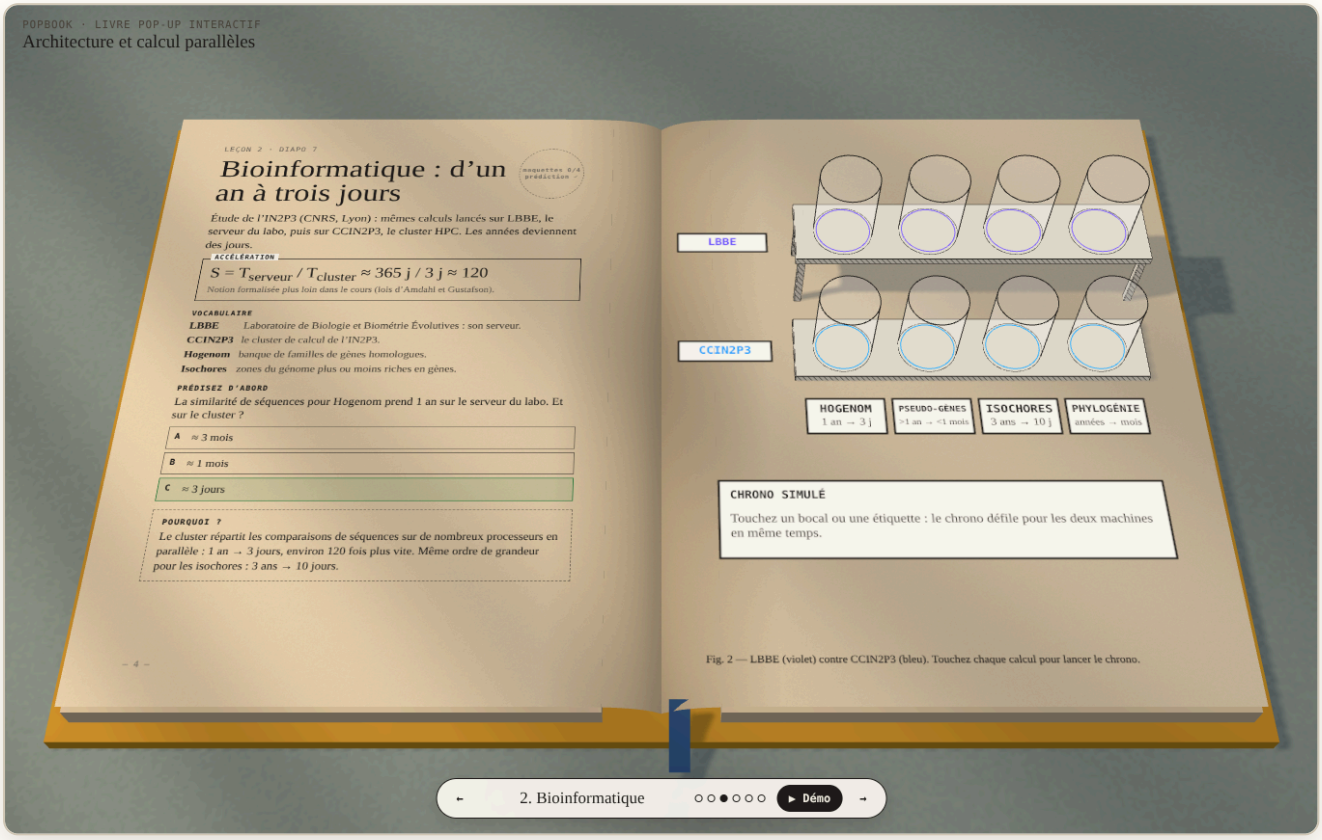
WHERE IS MY BOOK SAVED?

In the PopBook folder, under `books` → *your book's name*. It also appears in **Your books** at the bottom of the studio, every time you open PopBook.

6 ENJOY IT

Use your book

Each spread is one lesson: text on the left, a 3D model to play with on the right.



A lesson spread: the quiz is answered (green) and the flap is open.

Left page — the lesson

- **Key box**: the main formula or rule.
- **Vocabulary**: the important words.
- **Predict first**: guess the answer *before* playing with the model.
- **Lift the flap**: unlocks after you answer, and explains why.
- Some lessons have **sliders and buttons** that control the 3D model.

Right page — the 3D model

- **Click** the objects to make them move, fill, glow or change.
- **Hover** over an object to read what it is.
- Touch every part and answer the quiz: the lesson gets a red **stamp**.

Bottom bar

- ← → (or keyboard arrows) turn the page.
- ▶ **Demo** gives a guided tour of the current lesson.

6 SHARE IT

Share your book

Your friends don't need PopBook to read your book. Send them the HTML file.

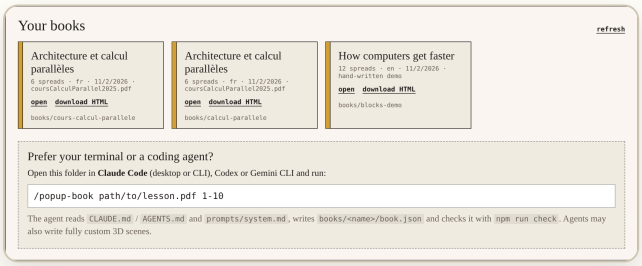
1. Click **Download as one HTML file** after building, or **download HTML** under the book in **Your books**.
2. Send that file by email, WhatsApp, Telegram, Google Drive, a USB stick...
3. They double-click it and it opens in their browser.

> **NEEDS INTERNET THE FIRST TIME**
> The file loads its 3D engine and fonts from the internet when it opens, so the reader must be online.

On phones too

On a phone or a narrow window, the 3D model sits at the top and the lesson scrolls underneath. Everything still works with your finger.

Your books library



Every book you've made, with **open** and **download HTML**.



The phone layout.

KEEP THIS PAGE

Next time: 3 steps

Once everything is installed, this is all you do.

1

Open a terminal in the Popbook folder

Windows: folder address bar → type **cmd** → Enter.
Mac: **cd** + space + drag the folder in.

2

Start PopBook

```
> npm start
```

3

Open your browser at

`localhost:5173`

To stop: click the terminal and press **Ctrl + C**, or close it.

Get the newest version of PopBook

If you downloaded the ZIP: download it again (step 2), then copy your old `books` folder into the new Popbook folder so you keep your books. Run `npm install` once in the new folder.

If you used Git: in the Popbook folder, run:

```
> git pull
> npm install
```

Optional: save your keys in a file

Instead of pasting your key every time, you can save it in PopBook's settings file. In the Popbook folder, make a copy of `.env.example` and name it `.env`. Open it with Notepad (or TextEdit on Mac), paste your key after the right `=` sign, for example `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY=sk-ant-…`, save, and restart PopBook. Windows may hide files starting with a dot: in File Explorer, choose **View → Show → File name extensions** and **Hidden items**.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

Troubleshooting

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
'node' or 'npm' is not recognized / command not found	Node.js isn't installed, or the terminal was open before you installed it. Close all terminals and open a new one. Still failing? Restart your computer, or reinstall Node.js (step 1).
running scripts is disabled on this system (Windows)	Use **Command Prompt** (cmd) instead of PowerShell. See step 3.
npm ERR! ... ENOENT ... package.json	The terminal isn't in the Popbook folder. Open it from the folder's address bar (step 3), or check you extracted the ZIP.
The browser says **This site can't be reached** at localhost:5173	PopBook isn't running. Look at the terminal: run `npm start` and keep the window open.
address already in use / port 5173 is taken	PopBook is probably already running in another terminal window: use that one. Or start on another port: in cmd `set PORT=5174 && npm start`, then open **localhost:5174**.
Claude Code — not installed in the list	Install and log in (step 4A), close every terminal, start PopBook again from a new one, and refresh the page.
Build my pop-up book stays grey	Read the small line under the button: it says what's missing (a PDF, a key, or an agent).
Build ends with **ERROR: 401** or "invalid key"	The key is wrong or was deleted. Copy it again from the website.
Build ends with "credit", "billing" or **429**	Your AI account has no credit left or hit its limit. Add credit, or wait a few minutes and try again.
Build ends with "model not found"	The model name is wrong or no longer exists. Clear the **Model** box to use the default, or check the service's website for current names.
"The JSON in the answer is cut off"	Open **Options** and set **Pages per AI call** to 5–8, or choose fewer pages.
The book opens but the **3D part is blank**	Your browser can't do 3D (WebGL). Update Chrome or Edge, update your graphics drivers, or try another browser.
The book's text is about the wrong thing / weak	Use a stronger AI (Claude Code or Claude API), fewer pages, and add **Extra instructions**. Scanned PDFs (photos of pages) work best with Claude or Gemini.

STILL STUCK?

Open an "Issue" on **github.com/AlphaaCode/Popbook** (Issues tab → New issue). Paste the red error line from the terminal or the Building panel — never your API key.

BETTER BOOKS

Tips for great books

- ✓ **Start small.** 5–10 pages per book. You can always make several books from one course.
- ✓ **Pick pages that teach one topic.** A chapter or a block of slides on the same idea gives the best spreads.
- ✓ **Use a strong AI.** Claude Code or the Claude API make the best choices of 3D models and the most faithful text.
- ✓ **Check the facts.** The AI is told to stay faithful to your pages, but read each lesson before you share it, like you'd proofread a classmate's notes.
- ✓ **Use Extra instructions** to set the level and tone: "explain like I'm in first year", "add more numbers", "keep the French terms".
- ✓ **Answer before you play.** The "predict first" question is the point: guess, then use the 3D model to see if you were right.

What it costs

OPTION	COST
PopBook itself	Free, open source (MIT licence).
Claude Code	Included in your Claude subscription; each book uses part of your plan's usage.
API keys	Pay per book. Our 5-page test with Claude cost about **$0.65**; longer ranges and bigger models cost more.
Ollama / LM Studio	Free (runs on your own computer), but books are usually weaker.

THAT'S IT

Install once, then: open a terminal in the Popbook folder → `npm start` → `localhost:5173` → drop a PDF → build. Have fun turning your courses into books you can actually play with.

PopBook Studio is open source: github.com/AlphaaCode/Popbook. Its look is inspired by "Every Joule" by Techartist; PopBook is not affiliated with Techartist.